

Contos Leap

Local circus artist Grace takes a glorious leap over granite rocks with the spectacular cliffs of Contos Springs Beach in the background.

Transcript

This is one of my very favorite photographs. My son happens to be a circus performer and so I had always been around Circus people as a circus Dad. A local circus performer is named Grace and we went down to Contos beach just to do a photo shoot and see what we could come up. I took this photo just as she leapt off a rock with the beautiful Cliffs of Contos in the background. It was not really early in the morning but the sun was coming up above the cliffs and it lights her up beautifully. Grace by name and Grace by nature.

Thank you Grace for permission to share this photo.

Contos Rock Dream

Dreamy seas just after a Contos sunset

Transcript

This is one of the older photos in the collection. I took it not long after I first got serious about photography. It was taken near one of the southern car parks of Contos. For a long time I liked the picture but I felt like it needed a subject in it - a character like a Neptune coming out of the water or somebody gracing that rock but then after a while I accepted that the rock can be the subject. It's kind of nice because there's no human element in that scene whatsoever. There's no development there's just a little snapshot of nature just after sunset and probably would have looked exactly the same 150 years ago when the Georgette was coming in to Calgardup Bay.

Contos South Mound

A daytime long exposure capturing the sea flowing over a granite mound at Contos South.

Transcript

This photo was taken during the day using an ND filter to block out a lot of the Light so I could get a longer exposure just to see the water flowing over the rock. I think the ND filter trick with the tripod can be a bit overused but sometimes it reveals something in a different way. This rock, which is sometimes way out in the water and othertimes almost underwater depending upon where the sand is on the beach on that particular day just had waves washing over it and I like the effect of the motion of the water flowing over the Rock. A long exposure highlights the shape a mound poking out of the beach almost as if its covered in snow.

Contos Spirit

Susanna, barefoot, in the coastal heath of Contos, is timeless in a scene impossible to date within a hundred years.

Cliff Island

This rocky island is a favourite of cliff jumpers in summer.

Transcript

This rock island is just across the channel from an outcrop that's between Foul Bay and Cozy Corner. It can't be seen from either of those beaches and I think that's why a lot of people don't realize that it's there. If you go there in summer on a nice day you'll see some dare devils swim across the channel climb over the island and jump off the cliff back into the water.

Cliff Island Sunset

Transcript

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Gnarabup Eye

Transcript

This picture doesn't really have a left or right or an up or down. It's a panorama that I took with the drone in 2026. If you look at it in landscape mode with the beach at the bottom of the picture then to the far left you can see the White Elephant cafe at Gnarabup beach and to the far right heading towards Surfers Point where the World Surfing League have their international competition there every year. Just slightly to the right of centre if you look very carefully you'll see what's known as the yellow buoy. Every single morning of the year Rain Hail or Shine there are several swimming social groups in Margaret River that swim from the White Elephant Cafe around the yellow buoy and back, a total distance of about 900 meters to a kilometer. I am in a group called the Sea Dragons.

Natural Spa Injidup

The Injidup Natural Spa is at the far end of the beach where the gig of the Georgette landed late December 1, 1876 with 14 crew and passengers including 20 year old mother Annie Simpson and her 5 month old baby Harry.

Walyormouring Lake

While camping in the wheatbelt on the way to the Dowerin Field Day, I came across this beautiful coloured lake.

Bolt of Rainbow

Transcript

A few years ago when a group of us were swimming in the early morning at Gnarabup beach there was a dark storm approaching over the horizon. Somehow a bolt of rainbow managed to strike its way through the gloom.

Calgardup Bay Autumn Panorama

This panorama is a composite photo and it formed the inspiration for one of the paintings of the Georgette landing which is on display at the exhibition.

Celestial Rock

Isaac Rock was known as Black Rock when the Georgette ran aground nearby 150 years ago. On the darkest winter night, the Milky Way points right to it.

Transcript

I always wanted to get a photograph of the Milky Way and Isaac rock in the same frame. So I picked the darkest night of the month of July this year and went down to Redgate Beach car park. The Milky Way could be seen vertically pointing up almost from due south. I moved the camera until it was right above Isaac rock and then took this 20 second exposure.

Georgette Bronzy

Transcript

This image was taken by the drone in autumn 2026. I'd been using the drone to observe the level of sand deposit around the wreck because it comes and goes quite a lot. This bronze whaler just cruised right by the wreck right by the Surfers and then took off and I lost it in the reef. On the very same day I saw a couple of dolphins also swim right by the wreck and got another photo that it's got a dolphin in it.

Georgette in Clear Water

On a rare day where clear water, low swell, sand washed away and offshore breeze combine to make the Georgette clearly visible.

Transcript

this picture was taken from the drone the very first time that I actually recognized the Georgette I knew roughly where it was that it was out there somewhere and I didn't realize that the visibility of the wreck was affected so much by the drifting of sand on the sea floor on this particular day of it was just a very rare combination and I just got lucky because it takes a day of low swell ideally less than a meter clear water and offshore Breeze so there's not much chop and sand cleared away from the wreck and also a low tide and all those things happen on that that day very very rare day you'd only get a handful of days like that in a year and couldn't help but see the outline of the ship and that's when that photo was taken

Georgette Summer

On a beautiful summers day new surfers learning on the smallest of swells right by the Georgette.

Transcript

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Grey Force

The Little Rock directs the force of the ocean swell into a vertical explosion that almost hides the larger Isaac Rock behind it.

Transcript

One of the interesting phenomenons to see at Redgate Beach is the huge splash made by the little rock that is just south of Isaac rock or the Black Rock as it used to be known in the time of the Georgette. Isaac Rock is the biggest rock by far in the group and yet the splash made by waves hitting it is not near as much as the waves hitting this little rock which is just to the south of it. It has to do with the kind of the concave shape of that rock face that faces the sea and the way the rocks under the water kind of pushing the wave power into it. When the swell is coming from the right direction and if there's any size to it and especially at low tide you can have these massive explosions of water that basically obliterate the Big Rock behind it so you can barely see it. On this day I took the photo in the mid afternoon and for me taking most the color out of the photo added a little bit to the impact of the power so that's why I've called this image Grey Force.

Hiding in Plain Sight

The wreck of the Georgette lies just offshore, hiding in plain sight with most beach goers completely unaware. She has rested there for 150 years.

Transcript

is Panorama taken from the drone was on a very very calm late autumn day when the Sea was quite flat and the water was very clear and that's actually a stacked image with the multiple shots taken from left to right and stitched together to get that Panorama of red gate from the ocean and can clearly see in the middle of the photo the shadow of the Georgette resting on the ocean floor

Isaac Rock Dolphins

A group of dolphins pass Isaac Rock as they head north.

Transcript

I fly the drone over the waves at redgate every once in a while just to keep an eye on the sand level around the shipwreck. That's a very very dynamic thing. One day there was this pod of dolphins swimming by and I managed to get a still image of them just as they passed by Isaac Rock.

Isaac Rock Red

Smokey Autumn days during burn-off season make for incredibly red sunsets In the South West. Isaac Rock stands here silhouetted against such a sunset in April.

Transcript

I took this photo quite a few years ago now in autumn and quite a distance inland there had been controlled burn in the smoke from the burn had drifted towards the coast and hungover the horizon and the red color is the natural color of sunlight through smoke at sunset so that's not a result of editing that's actually the color and makes quite a striking contrast with the silhouette of the Rock and

Little Rock In Winter 1

Two surfers paddle by the little rock that packs a big punch.

Osprey Eye

Ospreys are frequently seen on Isaac Rock watching out for a feed. This one was watching out at me as I walked by with the big rock in the background.

Transcript

You can often see ospreys around Calgardup Bay. Sometimes they're sitting on top of Isaac Rock. On this day I was walking towards the beach on the beach track and this osprey was just sitting on a post looking at me as I went by. In the background is Isaac rock but it looks quite blurry because I had quite an open aperture not much depth of focus.

Redgate Brown Day

On November 28, 2022 a thick smoke cloud from a burn-off one hundred kilometers inland hung over Margaret River and darkened the skies like an eclipse. Everything turned brown - sand, water and sky.

Transcript

It's not the most attractive name for a photo calling it the Redgate brown day but it really does describe what that day was like. I was at the farm and it was around midday on November 28th 2022. There had been a controlled burn off east of Margaret River I think it was somewhere like 100 kilometers away and just because of the unusual atmospheric conditions the smoke from that burn off had found its way west towards the coast and unusually the interface between the smoky air and the clear air underneath was very very distinct. It was like looking up at the underside of a carpet. There was no mixture of the clear air and the smoke and it was very very textured. As it was creating over the farm, I would guess it was no more than 50 meters of clear air until you hit the smoke, I'm not really exactly sure I just jumped in the car with the camera and went straight down to the beach just as it was crossing over the coast. It was incredible to have the color of the water, the base color of the vegetation everything else tinted with the color of the smoke. It was all completely brown. The sand was brown the water looked Brown, it looked like mud, almost all other colour was taken away and it was a very very cold and dark and brown scene.

Redgate Dronorama

Redgate Fishing

Fishing is a popular activity at the beach. In Autumn there is the famous salmon run where large schools form close to shore on the south west coast.

Transcript

This local Fisher woman was fishing at redgate one day as the waves were crashing onto the rocks and just looked such a great scene. She gave me permission to share the photo here.

Redgate Guitar

A guitar player sings from a rock after a beautiful autumn sunset at Redgate Beach.

Redgate Lightning

Lightning storm over the horizon off Redgate Beach after sunset

Redgate Panorama

This panorama centres on Isaac Rock in the fading light of dusk. The Georgette rests just to the left of it.

Redgate Surfer

The little rock makes a big splash, almost covering Isaac Rock as a surfer comes in after a sunset session at Redgate Beach.

Redgate Thunderstruck

A singer summons a lightning bolt.

Sandy Currents

The sand banks are incredibly dynamic. The flow of sand rarely pauses and is sometimes still seen suspended in water far from the beach. The short period of winter swells tends to erode the beaches. The longer period of summer swells allows more time for sand deposition. So the beach expands in summer and contracts in winter. The Georgette propeller was lost in the sand and is still under there somewhere.

Transcript

the flow of sand is recurring theme and a lot of the imagery of the coastline redgate Beach has almost a permanent rep at the northern end and it's well signed posted and regular swimmers there and Surfers are aware of it Surfers actually use it to their advantage and sometimes jump into the rip just to get out easily in quickly I've also seen people inadvertently coordinate in that rip and there have been several close call rescues of swimmers but when the currents are strong in the waters turbulent the sand gets picked up and sometimes gets carried along way and it becomes a tracer is a bit like smoking the air it kind of shows you exactly where the Water's flowing and you can get these incredible Eddies and currents and whirlpools and all kinds of formations that look like under cyclones especially from the drone and on that day the sand and the ways and the light just show how turbulent and how dynamic the water in the sand are

Sunset flight

A single bird is captured in 3 frames as it crosses an Isaac Rock sunset.

Surfer ends his session

A surfer stops to attend his leg rope at the end of a session surfing in the shadow of Isaac Rock.

Uneasy Calm

Uneasy Calm

Winter Rock

Isaac Rock was known as the Black Rock in the Georgettes day. It can be seen from Surfers Point to the north and from Hamelin Bay to the south. It is one of the more iconic rocks between the Capes and would have been a significant landmark for coastal navigators. It was renamed Isaac Rock in honour of Samuel Isaacs in recognition of his role in the rescue of Georgette survivors. The wreck is barely a hundred metres from it.

Wreck Lightning

Flying the drone over the wreck last Autumn during a lightning storm on the horizon.

Clyde Relics

This photo is part of a series I took of banks of the Clyde between Glasgow and Dumbarton. Many wrecked small boats and ships are exposed by the low tide.

Transcript

When you visit the Clyde River now, nothing really symbolises the decline of the ship building industry more than the site of relics like these that just appear as the tide drops. The Clyde river is very tidal there's quite a few meters between high and low tide so at high tide all these relics are covered and at low tide they're exposed again. Abandoned ships, boats, old wharves just being left there with the timber slowly decaying. You can walk through the bush on the on the banks of the Clyde and then all of a sudden a huge cast iron bollard will appear that at one time was holding on to ships. The jetties are gradually decaying and there's a series of photos I have taken of the relics of hulls of various sizes and of the timber wharves and jetties and what they look like at low tide today.

Clyde Wreck

In the Georgettes day, the river Clyde was home to the worlds largest ship building industry. Today there are only relics. The river is extremely tidal. At low tide, various ship carcasses are exposed only to be disappear later at high tide.

Transcript

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Dumbarton Castle on the Clyde

Dumbarton Castle sits high on a volcanic mound overlooking the Clyde River and shadowing the birthplace of the Georgette.

Transcript

When I went to Scotland I really wanted to find the site where the Georgette was built. It's right under the shadow of this large rock, it's almost a mountain on top of which is Dumbarton castle. It's has been there for centuries and the Georgette was built right below it on the river Leven, near to where the river Leven hits the river Clyde. Just across the river Leven from the Georgette Shipyard was the Shipyard where the Cutty Sark was built and that would be the most famous sailing cargo ship anywhere I think certainly from the 19th century and certainly the most famous British ship of that era. The Cutty Sark was built just three years before in 1869 so with hundreds of people working on that ship I would imagine that some of them probably also went and worked on the on the Georgette I'm sure that they moved around just depending on who needed Labor at the time. Dumbarton Castle itself is interesting and when I went up to have a look at some great photos of the whole area but also there's a story that William Wallace had been kept there after he was captured before he was taken to London where he met his in

Georgette Birthplace

Just across the river Leven is the location where the Georgette was built in 1872. It was the first ship built at Lower Woodyard by McKellar, McMillan & Sons. On the hill in the background is the famous Dumbarton Castle where William Wallace (Braveheart) was imprisoned and to its left, the site of construction of the worlds most famous nineteenth century sailing cargo ship - the Cutty Sark. It was built just 3 years before the Georgette and quite probably there were some tradies who worked on both.

Transcript

One of the things I wanted to do when I got to Scotland was to try and find the exact place that the Georgette was built. Here it is in this picture. That's the Leven River and the big hill in the background is the site of Dumbarton castle. One of the things that's known for is that it was where William Wallace (Braveheart) was imprisoned when he was captured before he was taken to London and later tortured. The Georgette was built at lower Wood Yard number one which just across the river. There's an existing Shipyard and to the right of that there's a bit of a field and that's where lower Wood Yard was. Something like 16 ships were built there by McKellar McMillan and Co before that company closed down and there was no exact sister ship of the Georgette. She was a one-off. To the left in that picture in the shadow of Dumbarton castle is the site of the building of the Cutty Sark which is perhaps the most famous cargo sailing ship of all time certainly the most famous British sailing ship. The Cutty Sark has been preserved and I went to visit the museum at Greenwich where you can go on board and have a look around. It was built three years before the Georgette and the site where it was built has now been filled in and turned into soccer field and that's another symbol of the loss of the once epic ship building industry on the Clyde River. I'd like to think that some of the hundreds of tradies that would have worked on that ship might have happened across the river and perhaps also worked on the building of the Georgette.

Historic Oak

This beautiful oak grows over a 14th century settlement and grave site. It is on an island in the famous Loch Lomond where it might have had some protection from the resource demands of the ship building industry that stripped much of the natural forest of Scotland and England.

Transcript

The reason that this photograph is in the exhibition is that I'm fascinated with the story of wood that's survived and still exists in shipwrecks. If you dive on the Georgette on the right day where there's not much sand over it you might be lucky enough to see remnants of what they call the ceiling which was the wooden lining around the inside of the hull and there are some planks there and when they're visible you can see the grain in the wood you can see the planks clearly lined up side by side. It's incredible that after 150 years they're still there and they're not done yet. If you think about the life of that wood, the tree that it came from and where it's origins may have began, the seedling that created the tree that produced the wood that now lies at the bottom of a Calgaidup Bay could have sprung to life 300 years ago or more. So you're seeing and able to touch something that actually predates the arrival of Europeans in this country. When I first realized that after talking to an indigenous elder Zach Webb, it made me think about the timber in the shipwreck in a completely different way.

This picture is of an oak tree over an ancient Scottish burial ground on an island in Loch Lomond.

Leven Bridge

The bridge over the Leven seems quiet and tranquil now. But 150 years ago this area was bustling and would have smelt like hot metal and noisy with the sound of rivets being hammered into iron plates. The Georgette was built just a kilometer down stream of the bridge.

Transcript

I decided to include this picture of the Leven Bridge which I took when I visited Scotland earlier this year because it's only a kilometre upstream from where the Georgette was built. At the time of the building of this bridge the ship building industry on the Clyde would have been in full swing and the whole town would have smelled the smoke from the fires used to forged steel. The sound of rivets being belted into steel hulls would have been heard everywhere. It's a very different scene now and there's nothing really but relics of the former glory of that industry.

River Leven from Dumbarton Castle

This panorama shows the former site of the Lower Woodyard shipyard where the Georgette was built. It is on the River Leven just before it runs into the Clyde. On the right side there is now a soccer field on reclaimed land where there was once a canal used to build the Cutty Sark just 3 years before the Georgette.
